

Is the pursuit of excellence always beneficial to your society?

Interpretation of terms:

‘excellence’: the quality of being outstanding or extremely good and so surpasses ordinary standards. It is often used as a standard of performance as measured, for example, through economic indicators, ranking, awards, etc. The simplest concept of excellence is striving after perfection – a perfection which perhaps can never be achieved

‘pursuit of excellence’: To pursue something means that one must **continuously** put in efforts to achieve a particular aim over a long period of time. However, excellence is a moving target, thus one needs to continuously pursue it to remain ‘excellent’. The implication is that this pursuit is a relentless one because excellence demands continued work and sustainability.

‘always beneficial’: that benefits are reaped at all times without exception.

‘your society’: Singapore context

Possible Stand:

Disagree with the statement. This question contains the absolute term ‘always’ and therefore, it is untenable for us to agree with it. Underlying the use of this absolute term is the assumption that pursuing excellence is beneficial and that the benefits are reaped at all times without any negative consequences. However, the reality is that there is a cost exacted by such a pursuit and the demands may be debilitating in the long term.

Approach:

Part A: Examine the reasons for believing that pursuing excellence is beneficial to Singapore.

Part B: Address the implications of the absolute term ‘always’ and present the rebuttal via an examination of the cost and demands of such a pursuit in the long term.

Suggested Outline:

Part A: Examine the reasons for believing that pursuing excellence is beneficial to Singapore.

1. **Pursuing excellence will raise the bar of our performance and help us achieve our goals in a competitive environment. This has always been the key to Singapore’s relevance and survival.** Excellence is about stepping outside the comfort zone, training with a spirit of endeavour, and accepting the inevitability of trials and tribulations. With the pursuit of excellence as our objective, we are embarking on a journey that will translate our efforts into achievements and transcend mediocrity. Singapore has routinely benchmarked her planning to the best in the world in her pursuit for excellence. For example, we have always sought to recruit the best and brightest people in our endeavours to become a world economic and educational leader in our short history as a

nation. This is reflected in the many areas of achievement such achieving a GDP Per Capita of 65,233.000 USD in Dec 2019 (as one of the top 10 wealthiest nation in the world) and topping the table in the 2012 and 2015 PISA ranking for Mathematics and Science for 15 year olds.

2. Pursuing excellence requires continued work and sustainability. **To sustain such a performance at a high level will necessitate the need to reinvent ourselves, thereby promoting innovation and improvement which are critical for Singapore's continued survival in an information and innovation-driven globalized economy.** Singapore has to repeatedly reinvent itself by creating or re-asserting qualities that helped attract capital, talent and trade. An example would be our pursuit for excellence in research and development, Singapore is now home to more than 6,000 researchers from across the globe. On top of home-grown talent such as Wong Tien Yin (NUS Provost's Chair Professor and Vice Dean) , Professor Tan Chorh Chuan (Chief Health Scientist at the Ministry of Health)and Professor John Eu-Li Wong, NUS Senior Vice-President (Health Innovation and Translation)and many world-renowned scientific talents who have moved to Singapore to head the city-state's research institutes, consortia and laboratories. Our thriving research environment now accounts for some 7354 patents owned by Singapore in 2019.

In December 2020, it was announced that a total of \$2.2 billion would be funnelled towards training future researchers and scientists over the next five years under Singapore's Research, Innovation and Enterprise (RIE) 2025 plan. The plan maps out the country's research and development strategy from 2021 to 2025. To grow the talent pool with skills in technology commercialization, a new Innovation and Enterprise Fellowship programme will be launched under RIE2025. The government believes that talent development is crucial for Singapore to build a strong foundation of scientists and engineers who will "push the boundaries of technology" and help the country succeed as a trusted digital innovation hub.

Part B: Address the implications of the absolute term 'always' and present the rebuttal via an examination of the cost and demands of such a pursuit in the long term.

3. However, excellence is a continuously moving target that must be pursued through persistence. What is considered excellent today would not be excellent after some time, thus one needs to be continuously upgrading to achieve excellence and remain excellent. **To be always pursuing excellence implies that the pursuit is relentless and such an endeavour might not be the healthiest and will exact a cost on its people.** For example, in 2014, the Singapore Business Review reported that 55 percent of respondents from the Jobstreet.com survey on employee health at work said that stress is the major reason for mental fatigue at work and burnout. And even if one may be coping well with the high stress levels, prolonged periods of stress can still pose a health risk.

4. While pursuing excellence encourages competition to achieve greater heights, when we keep measuring ourselves against others, especially in high stakes competition, it can undermine our focus and distract us from our actual goals. **Our striving for excellence can thus degenerate into the life-draining burden of perfectionism – a dysfunctional desire to be perfect.** This dysfunctional desire to be perfect is exemplified in the double tragedy of a 16-year-old girl who committed suicide over scoring 2 Bs in English and Mathematics for her 'O' Levels. The grief-stricken and guilt-ridden mother, who wanted to push the teen, a straight-A student from a top school, to excel, also killed herself three months later, leaving the teen's father mentally unstable. This is a growing concern for Singapore as more children and teenagers have been seeking help for suicidal thoughts. According to Samaritans of Singapore (SOS), in 2013, 224 children and teens aged 19 and below wrote in to them through its E-mail Befriending Service. From this group, 163 were considered to be at real risk of suicide. In 2017, there were seven suicides by teenage boys. Nineteen boys aged 10 to 19 committed suicide in 2018. One of the possible contributing factors to the increase in suicide is the culture of perfectionism – a reflection of our deepest insecurities as a nation. This culture is constantly reinforced by the government, the media and even our family. Living in a society that stresses the importance of masculine qualities as a measure of success, we grow impatient toward behaviours that seem to depict weakness. Men are stereotypically expected to be tough, stoic, and financially stable. The slightest hint of vulnerability can be seen as an imperfection. Thus, pursuing excellence can also have a dark side to it as it is paradoxical in nature.

5. **In spite of the heavy price paid, there is no guarantee that pursuing excellence actually leads to it, and thus it is a waste of resources.** Based on anecdotal evidence, achieving excellence is more often than not, a combination of many circumstances where the conscious pursuit of excellence is not one of them. This pursuit, which encompasses one's commitment and belief, merely determines one's perspective and orientation that will influence one's determination to persist in the face of obstacles. Thus it is a mistaken belief to think that one's commitment to pursue excellence will always translate into benefits. For example, Singapore's ambition to pursue excellence in sports is reflected in the many initiatives implemented: from the government's commitment to spend \$500 million to implement recommendations put up by the committee on Sporting Singapore in 2001 to the present High Performance System (HPS) implemented to support Singapore athletes to continue to achieve success at major games. However, our achievements in the sports arena remain modest owing to a limited talent pool and our culture of pragmatism.